

WF

CHRISTMAS 2026 EDITION

WILEY FOX TRAVEL
FAMILIES AND SOLO TRAVELLERS

THE WILEY FOX GUIDE TO

New York

For families & solo travellers

WILEY FOX RATING • MODERATE

3

OUT OF 5 • POLICE DATA APR 2026 TO JUN 2026

CREATOR FEELING 4/5 • COMFORTABLE, WITH BIG-CITY AWARENESS

\$3

SUBWAY OR BUS RIDE, TAP TO PAY

Rides are free after 12 in seven days, so a week tops out at \$35 (MTA, Sept 2026).

2,300

CRIMES A MONTH NEAR TIMES SQUARE

Almost half are thefts - and it's the scam hotspot creators warn about most.

38

CREATORS • 60 VIDEOS

Paraphrased and credited, cross-checked with NYPD data.

New York is easier to plan than it looks: Manhattan is a grid, the subway runs 24 hours, and you tap your bank card to ride. The big decision is where to sleep. Creators agree Midtown is the simplest first-time base but also the most expensive, and several now point to Long Island City, the Financial District or Brooklyn for better value a short ride away. Short-term rentals have been effectively banned since a 2023 law, so plan on a hotel.

For families, many of the best things are free - Central Park, the Staten Island Ferry past the Statue of Liberty, the High Line, the Brooklyn Bridge and the Public Library - and the Natural History Museum is a favourite with every creator who took children. Up to three children under 44 inches (about 112 cm) ride the subway free with a paying adult.

For solo travellers it is a city that never really stops. The risks are ordinary big-city ones - theft, scams and the odd unsettling moment on a late train - and they cluster in predictable places. This guide shows you where, using the same NYPD data that powers the Wiley Fox map.

WF

Check any hotel street on the Wiley Fox map before you book - it covers New York with the latest NYPD data, so you can see recorded crime around the block, not just the neighbourhood.

Fast facts

CURRENCY

US dollar (USD) - cards and phones almost everywhere, but carry a little cash for carts and Chinatown

LANGUAGE

English

TIME ZONE

Eastern Time (UTC-5, UTC-4 in summer) - usually five hours behind the UK

PLUG

Type A and B, 120V - pack an adaptor and check hairdryers

EMERGENCY

911 · non-emergency 311 (call or text)

ENTRY

UK visitors need an approved ESTA before flying - apply only at esta.cbp.dhs.gov (\$40 since 30 Sept 2025)

TIPPING

About 20% in sit-down restaurants - check for an added service charge. Sales tax (8.875%) is added at the till

BEST TIME

April to June, or September to October. January to March is cheapest

THE FESTIVE SEASON

Christmas in New York

From Thanksgiving to New Year, New York is at its most magical - and its busiest and most expensive. More than seven million visitors arrive between Thanksgiving and Christmas, and hotel prices can be three to five times higher than the rest of the year. The trick every creator repeats: go early in the morning, on weekdays, and book ahead.

Christmas markets



Photo: Rhododendrites • CC BY-SA 4.0



Bank of America Winter Village at Bryant Park

MIDTOWN • 28 OCT 2026 - 28 FEB 2027 • GREAT FOR KIDS

The biggest market, with more than 180 kiosks, food stalls and a 17,000 sq ft rink that's free if you bring your own skates (reserve a free ticket online). Clean public toilets on site.

Crowds: Wall-to-wall at weekends and nearer Christmas, with queues of up to 100 people for hot chocolate. Quieter midday on weekdays between meal times.

Via [Happy to Wander](#), [Travel The Top](#), [Creative Travel Guide](#), [Manps On The Map](#), [Through My Lens](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Up Up & Our Way](#), [Katelyn DeWitt](#), [Traveling with Tim](#), [Michael In The City](#)

Free entry • hot chocolate about \$7-10 (2025) • skate hire \$15-55 (2025)

DETAILS

Union Square Holiday Market

UNION SQUARE • USUALLY FROM LATE NOVEMBER - CHECK THE OFFICIAL SITE • GREAT FOR KIDS



About 100-150 open-air vendors right by the subway, with plenty of hot food. Pete's Tavern nearby is a heavily decorated historic bar.

Crowds: Smaller and calmer than Bryant Park on weekdays; very busy on Saturdays. Pickpockets work the stalls - keep wallets in front.

Via [Traveling with Tim](#), [Through My Lens](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Up Up & Our Way](#), [Mohuya Khan](#)

Free entry

DETAILS

Columbus Circle Holiday Market

COLUMBUS CIRCLE • USUALLY FROM LATE NOVEMBER - CHECK THE OFFICIAL SITE • GREAT FOR KIDS



Over 100 stalls by the south-west corner of Central Park - many the same as Bryant Park, as the markets share operators. Handy before a skate at Wollman Rink.

Crowds: Noticeably quieter than Bryant Park.

Via [Through My Lens](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

Free entry · market prices carry a premium

DETAILS



Grand Central Holiday Fair

MIDTOWN EAST • USUALLY FROM LATE NOVEMBER - CHECK THE OFFICIAL SITE • GREAT FOR KIDS

An indoor market - a good escape from the cold - plus the New York Transit Museum's model-train display in the terminal.

Crowds: Busy at rush hour; mid-morning is easier.

Via [Up Up & Our Way](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Michael In The City](#)

Free entry

DETAILS



Photo: Kidfly182 · CC BY 4.0

Chelsea Market at Christmas

CHELSEA · USUALLY FROM LATE NOVEMBER - CHECK THE OFFICIAL SITE · GREAT FOR KIDS

Indoor food hall with Christmas pop-ups and events, and in 2023 a gingerbread village of over a thousand houses. Food and desserts out of the cold.

Crowds: Busy at weekends; combine with a High Line walk in the morning.

Via [Happy to Wander](#), [Manps On The Map](#), [Traveling with Tim](#)

Free entry · some events paid (\$25 in 2024)

DETAILS

Lights, rinks and festive sights



Photo: Anthony Quintano from Mount Laurel, United States · CC BY 2.0



Rockefeller Center tree & rink

MIDTOWN • TREE LIT IN EARLY DECEMBER IN 2024 AND 2025; THE 2026 DATE ISN'T PUBLISHED YET - CHECK THE OFFICIAL SITE • GREAT FOR KIDS

The classic scene: a tree of 70-80 ft with 50,000 LED lights above the famous rink. The tree is lit from early morning (about 5-6am) until midnight, so sunrise gives calm photos.

Crowds: The busiest spot in the city at Christmas: hours-long photo queues, closed roads and barely walkable rink areas on Friday and Saturday evenings. Go on a weekday, at dawn or just before midnight.

Via [Exotic Vacation](#), [Manps On The Map](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Through My Lens](#), [Michael In The City](#), [Danny Rayes](#), [Happy to Wander](#)

Tree free • rink \$21 daytime to \$114 at peak, plus \$12 skates (2025)

DETAILS



Wollman Rink & cheaper rinks

CENTRAL PARK • WINTER SEASON - CHECK THE OFFICIAL SITE • GREAT FOR KIDS

Wollman in Central Park is bigger than Rockefeller's and a fraction of the price, with skyline views. Brooklyn Bridge Park's rink was about \$10 with no holiday surge in 2025.

Crowds: Weekday mornings are cheapest and quietest; evenings and Christmas Eve cost far more and need booking.

Via [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Travel The Top](#), [Dicas Nova York](#)

Wollman \$15-38 plus \$12 skates (2025)

DETAILS

Holiday windows & light shows

FIFTH AVENUE & HERALD SQUARE • USUALLY FROM LATE NOVEMBER - CHECK RETAILERS' SITES • GREAT FOR KIDS

Saks, Bergdorf Goodman, Cartier and Macy's go all out; Sixth Avenue has giant ornaments and the Peninsula and Lotte Palace lobbies are free to walk into. The Saks light show ran every 10 minutes from 5pm in 2024 but was cancelled in 2025 - check before you go.

Crowds: Body-to-body in early evening. Go late, once most visitors have gone back to their hotels, or first thing.

Via [Exotic Vacation](#), [Creative Travel Guide](#), [Happy to Wander](#), [Taylor Bell](#), [Travel The Top](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Through My Lens](#), [Up Up & Our Way](#)

Free

DETAILS



Photo: Alex Liivet from Chester, United Kingdom · [CC0](#)

Macy's Santaland

HERALD SQUARE • LATE NOVEMBER TO CHRISTMAS EVE (2024) - CHECK THE OFFICIAL SITE • GREAT FOR KIDS

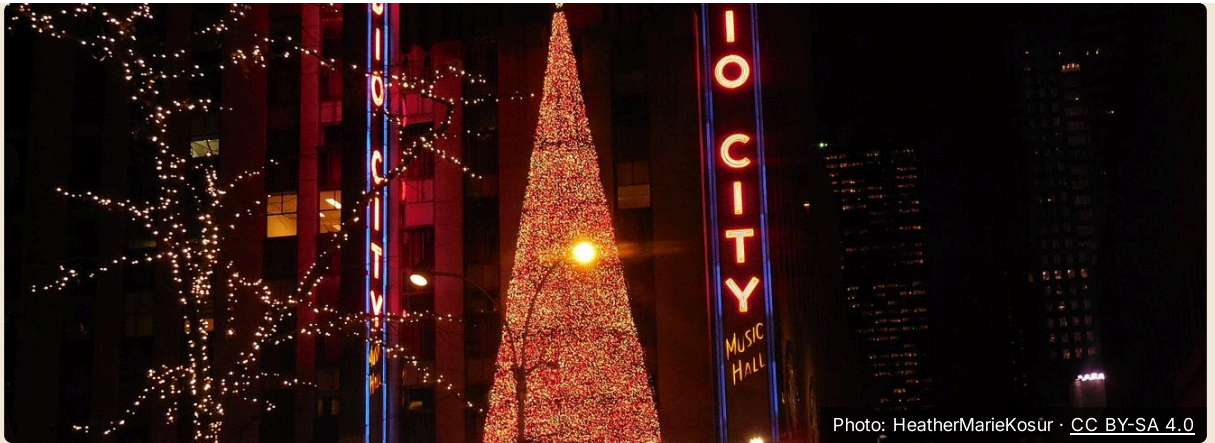
Santa on the 8th floor of the Herald Square flagship - a favourite with young children. Outside, a double-decker carousel was \$7 a ride in 2025.

Crowds: Reservations sold out for a weekend in December 2025, so book as soon as they open. For the windows, arrive at the 10am opening.

Via [Travel The Top](#), [Creative Travel Guide](#), [Up Up & Our Way](#), [Michael In The City](#)

Free with a reservation

DETAILS



Radio City Christmas Spectacular

MIDTOWN • USUALLY FROM NOVEMBER - CHECK THE OFFICIAL SITE • GREAT FOR KIDS

The Rockettes' 90-minute show with no interval, suitable for all ages; creators who went rated it far better than expected. No large bags or photography - one creator paid about \$10 to store a bag nearby.

Crowds: Up to five shows a day, selling out weeks ahead. Security is slow; arrive 30 minutes early.

Via [Exotic Vacation](#), [Through My Lens](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Travel The Top](#)

From about \$70 (2025)

DETAILS



Dyker Heights Christmas lights

DYKER HEIGHTS (BROOKLYN) • LATE NOVEMBER TO NEW YEAR'S EVE (2024) • GREAT FOR KIDS

Whole blocks of extravagantly lit homes. Creators split: some call it a must, others say it's crowded and about an hour each way by subway plus a 15-20 minute walk, so skip it if you're short on time. Recorded crime is among the lowest we checked.

Crowds: Crowded on evenings nearer Christmas; plan your route back before you go.

Via [Travel The Top](#), [Creative Travel Guide](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Up Up & Our Way](#)

Free

DETAILS



NYBG Holiday Train Show

THE BRONX • WINTER SEASON - CHECK THE OFFICIAL SITE • GREAT FOR KIDS

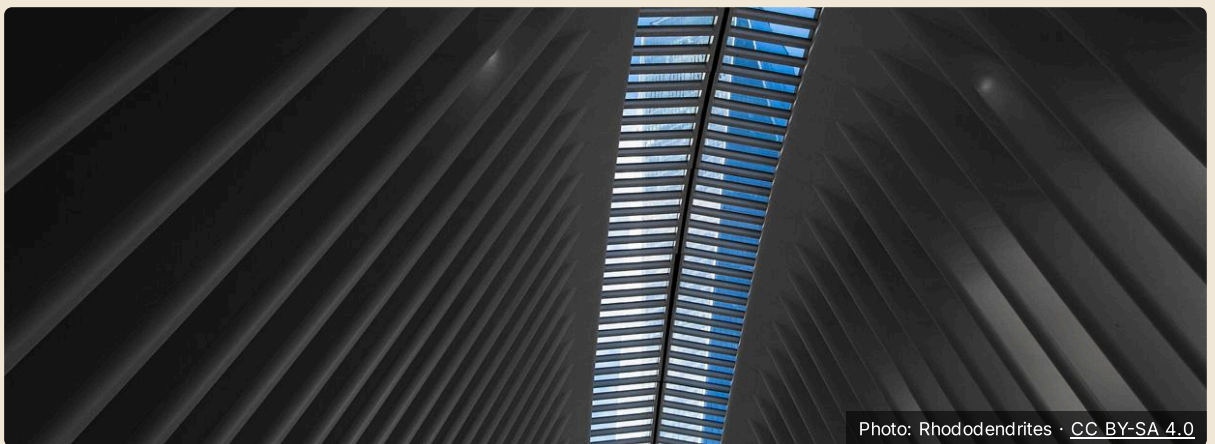
Model trains run through nearly 200 New York landmarks made from bark, leaves and other plant materials. A must for train-mad children, reached by Metro-North.

Crowds: Timed tickets keep it manageable.

Via [Travel The Top](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Creative Travel Guide](#)

Paid – book ahead

DETAILS



Downtown trees & the Oculus

FINANCIAL DISTRICT & SEAPORT • DECEMBER • GREAT FOR KIDS

The tree by the Stock Exchange, near the Charging Bull and Fearless Girl, lights at Zuccotti Park and decorations in the Oculus. One creator liked the Wall Street tree more than Rockefeller's; Pier 17 at the Seaport has a rooftop rink with Brooklyn Bridge views.

Crowds: Far quieter than Midtown - the best crowd-free Christmas photos in the city.

Via [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Up Up & Our Way](#), [Manps On The Map](#), [Through My Lens](#), [Happy to Wander](#)

Free

DETAILS

Staying safe in the Christmas crowds

Crowds at the tree and on Fifth Avenue

In December, pavements around Rockefeller Center are body-to-body and police close roads to manage the crowds. That area already records about 2,200 crimes a month, almost half theft. Go at dawn or on a weekday, carry little, and keep bags zipped and in front.

Via [Katelyn DeWitt](#), [Manps On The Map](#), [Danny Rayes](#), [Sarah Funk](#)

Pickpockets at the markets

Busy stalls are ideal for pickpockets - one creator saw a wallet taken from a shopper at Union Square as they paid. The circle around Bryant Park records about 2,400 crimes a month and the most pickpocket and theft-from-the-person complaints in our sample (about 64 a month). Pay with your phone or card, and don't hang anything off a backpack.

Via [Mohuya Khan](#)

Have a lost-child plan

Before you enter a market, rink or parade crowd, agree a meeting point you can all see - a named stall, the rink entrance or a shop front. Creators describe big holiday crowds with no toilets and people camping for a view. A Wiley Fox QR wristband on each child means anyone who finds them can reach you straight away.

Via [Sarah Funk](#)

Dress for the cold

Creators quote December highs from about 42F to 58F (6-14C) and lows around freezing, with wind that bites. Wear layers, a windproof coat, hat and gloves. They disagree on boots: one says trainers are fine, another packs waterproof boots. Sunset is around 4pm, most park toilets close around then, and subway steps get slippery in wet weather.

Via [The Quick Advisors](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Dicas Nova York](#)

New Year's Eve in Times Square

Pedicabs and Santa photos

It's free, but viewing pens opened at 3pm in 2025, with no toilets, no re-entry and all bags searched - backpacks, umbrellas and alcohol aren't allowed. Expect hundreds of thousands of people and a long, freezing wait. Not one for young children; Sarah Funk says skip it. Hotel viewing packages ran \$500 to over \$1,000.

Via [Sarah Funk](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

Decorated pedicabs around Rockefeller Center charged \$7-10 a minute in 2025, and costumed Santas expect payment for photos. Agree a price first, or just say no.

Via [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

Book hotels as early as you can - one creator suggests up to a year ahead - and Radio City, Santaland, rinks and restaurants weeks in advance. Most 2026 dates, including the tree lighting, aren't published yet: markets usually open from late November, so check official sites; Bryant Park runs 28 Oct 2026 - 28 Feb 2027. Many Chinatown restaurants stay open on Christmas Day.

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Clip a Wiley Fox QR wristband on each child. If you get separated in a crowd, anyone who scans it can contact you straight away - no app needed on their side.

WHAT THE DATA AND THE CREATORS SAY

*How it feels, and what the numbers show**The data*

New York is far safer than its film reputation and most visits pass without trouble. The main risk for visitors is theft - pickpocketing, phone theft and street scams - and it clusters in the busiest parts of Midtown, especially around Times Square. Serious violence against tourists is rare; take normal big-city care late at night, on quiet streets and on near-empty trains.

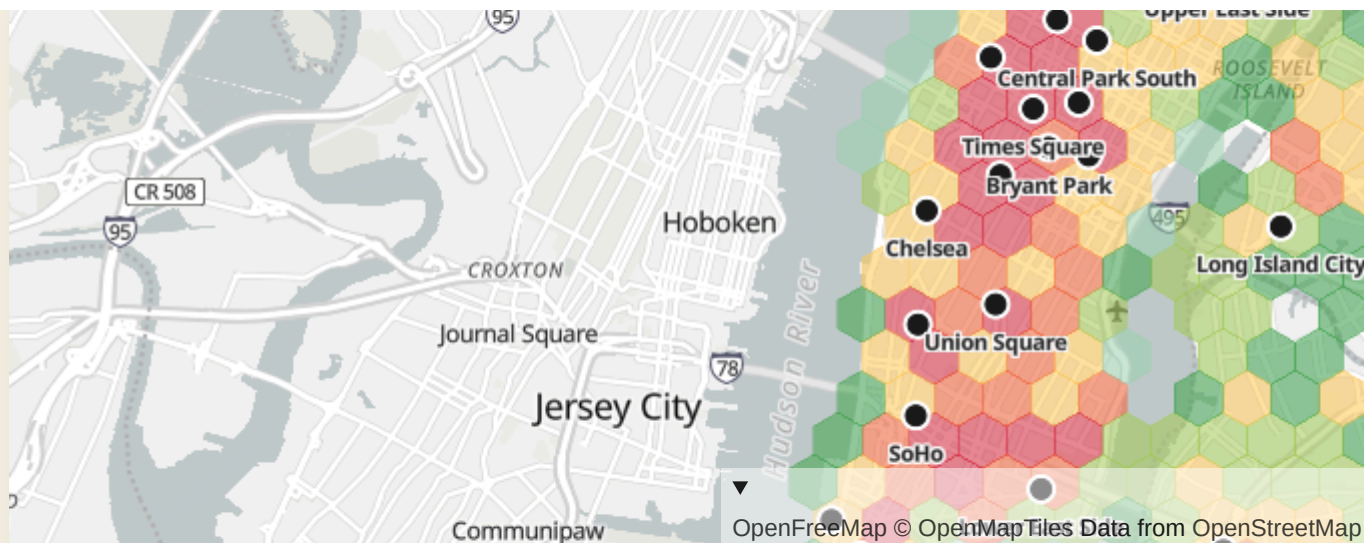
The creators

Most creators we reviewed say New York feels safer than people expect, and one who rode the subway more than 50 times in four weeks had no problems. The repeated warnings are practical: keep phones and wallets in front, ignore anyone offering something 'free' in Times Square, and avoid empty subway cars. Creators split on late nights: some ride the subway at any hour, while two women creators take a car or bus after about 11pm to midnight.

The Wiley Fox crime map of New York

Every recorded crime in Jun 2026 from NYPD Complaint Data (NYC Open Data), weighted by seriousness the same way as the Wiley Fox app and grouped into 350-metre hexagons. Colours compare each hexagon with the rest of New York: red marks the busiest 5% of the city. Blank areas had no recorded crime. Busy tourist districts show up red partly because so many people pass through them. For a street-level score, open the Wiley Fox map.



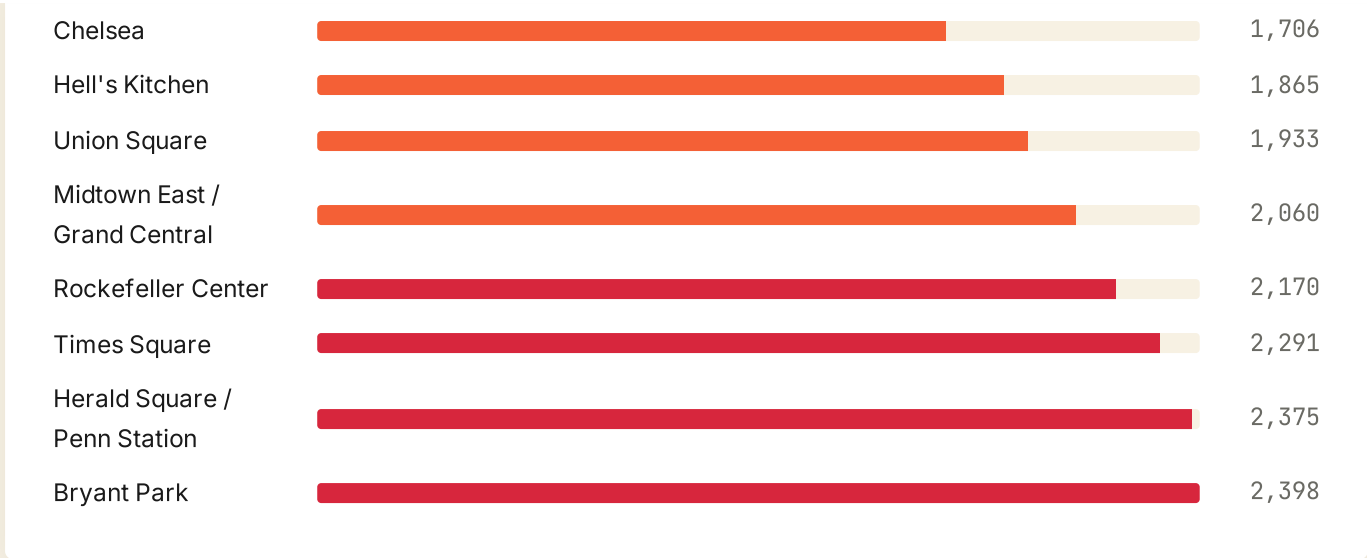


40,922 crimes · NYPD Complaint Data (NYC Open Data) · [Check any street live on the Wiley Fox map](#)

Recorded crime by area

Recorded crimes are the monthly average for April to June 2026 within roughly one mile of each area centre (NYPD complaint data, NYC Open Data - the latest published; July to September is not yet released). Busy tourist areas record more crime partly because far more people pass through them. The Midtown circles for Times Square, Bryant Park, Rockefeller Center, Herald Square and Grand Central overlap heavily, so read them as one busy zone.

Dyker Heights		324
Long Island City		400
Upper West Side		583
Upper East Side		615
Williamsburg		630
Battery Park City		688
Financial District		708
DUMBO		885
Lower East Side		1,309
Greenwich Village		1,467
Columbus Circle		1,520
SoHo		1,590
Central Park South		1,638



Lowest Lower Moderate High Highest

How New York City compares with the rest of the US

Offences per 100,000 residents in 2025, as reported to the FBI. New York City is about 2.0 times the US average for violent crime and 1.5 times for property crime. Violent crime fell about 5% on 2024 and property crime about 5%. Big cities always sit above the national average: millions of commuters and visitors are counted as victims but not as residents, and crime is concentrated in some neighbourhoods rather than spread evenly.

	VIOLENT CRIME	PROPERTY CRIME
New York City police	660	2,300
Chicago police	420	2,956
New York State	368	1,567
US average	329	1,552

per 100,000 residents, 2025

Violent crime is murder, rape, robbery and aggravated assault. Property crime is burglary, theft and vehicle theft. For the street you are on, use the area figures above or the Wiley Fox map. Source: [FBI Crime Data Explorer, agency summary data \(2024–2025\)](#)

Areas to take extra care

None of these are no-go areas. Know the pattern, and plan your timing and your route home.

● Times Square

TAKE MOST CARE: ALL DAY, BUSIEST LATE AFTERNOON AND EVENING

About 2,300 recorded crimes a month within a mile, almost half of them theft, with around 60 pickpocket and theft-from-the-person complaints a month. Creators say almost every tourist scam happens here: costumed characters charging \$20 or more for photos, 'free' CDs and bracelets that end in a demand for money. It is not unsafe - it is busy. Go for a show or a photo, keep your phone in front, and keep walking.

2,291 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, violence, harassment

Via [Sarah Funk](#), [Wolters World](#), [Jon Barr](#), [Exotic Vacation](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Manps On The Map](#)

● Rockefeller Center & Fifth Avenue

TAKE MOST CARE: LATE NOVEMBER TO EARLY JANUARY, EVENINGS AND WEEKENDS

About 2,200 recorded crimes a month, almost half theft. At Christmas the pavements are body-to-body, roads are closed for crowds and photo queues by the tree can take hours. Decorated pedicabs here charged \$7 to \$10 a minute in 2025, and people in Santa costumes expect payment for photos.

2,170 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, violence, harassment

Via [Danny Rayes](#), [Manps On The Map](#), [Katelyn DeWitt](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

● Herald Square / Penn Station

TAKE MOST CARE: ALL DAY, ESPECIALLY AROUND THE STATIONS

One of the highest counts in our sample - about 2,400 a month, nearly half theft. Outside Penn Station, Moynihan Train Hall and Port Authority, strangers pick up bags uninvited and then demand a tip. Hold on to your luggage and say no firmly.

2,375 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, violence, harassment

Via [Jon Barr](#)

● Union Square

TAKE MOST CARE: HOLIDAY MARKET SEASON AND WEEKENDS

About 1,900 recorded crimes a month and more than half are theft, one of the highest theft shares we found. One creator saw a wallet stolen from a shopper paying at a busy market stall. Keep wallets in front pockets and nothing hanging off the outside of a backpack.

1,933 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, violence, harassment

Via [Mohuya Khan](#)

● Battery Park & the ferry terminals

TAKE MOST CARE: DAYTIME, WHEN THE STATUE OF LIBERTY BOATS RUN

Recorded crime is low - about 700 a month - but this is where fake ticket sellers work. The Staten Island Ferry is free, so never buy a ticket for it, and only Statue City Cruises sells genuine Liberty and Ellis Island tickets.

688 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, other, violence

Via [Jon Barr](#), [Exotic Vacation](#), [Sarah Funk](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

● Central Park after dark

TAKE MOST CARE: EVENINGS, AND ALL DAY ON THE SOUTHERN EDGE

Central Park is a highlight by day. One creator says locals advise not going in after dark. Along the southern edge, pedicabs charge by the minute - one creator reports about \$150 for 10 minutes - so check the posted price first. Another creator advises against the horse-drawn carriages on welfare grounds.

1,638 crimes a month nearby · top: theft, violence, harassment

Via [thefunsizedfoodie](#), [Wolters World](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

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Heading back late? Use Safest Route on [thewileyfox.com](#) to pick a busier, lower-crime walk from the subway to your hotel, and keep SOS one tap away.

Scams and tricks creators keep seeing

Costumed characters & 'free' gifts

In Times Square, nothing is free: CDs, bracelets, 'monks' with donation books and photos with costumed characters all end in a demand for money - \$20 or more in one creator's experience. Don't make eye contact; keep walking.

Via [Wolters World](#), [Jon Barr](#), [Exotic Vacation](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Manps On The Map](#)

Pedicab pricing

Pedicabs in Midtown and around Central Park charge by the minute - \$7 to \$10 a minute near Rockefeller Center in 2025. Agree the total price before you sit down, or walk.

Via [Wolters World](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

Fake ferry & Statue tickets

Sellers around Battery Park offer tickets for the Staten Island Ferry, which is free, and

Airport ride touts

Anyone approaching you in arrivals, or holding an 'Uber' sign, is not a licensed

'Statue tours' that don't land on Liberty Island. Buy only from Statue City Cruises.

Via [Jon Barr](#), [Exotic Vacation](#), [Sarah Funk](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

driver. Use the official taxi line - a real yellow cab shows ID and 'TLC' on the plate - or book in the app.

Via [Jon Barr](#), [Sarah Funk](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Mohuya Khan](#)

Marked-up show tickets

Street sellers and look-alike reseller sites charge far more for Broadway and observation-deck tickets. Buy from the show's own site, the TKTS booth, or official lotteries.

Via [Jon Barr](#), [Mohuya Khan](#)

Phone and card distraction

Two tricks one creator describes: someone selling sweets asks to borrow your phone for a payment app, then drains your accounts; and at ATMs, cash is dropped behind you to distract you while your card is swapped. Never hand over your phone; cover the keypad.

Via [Jon Barr](#)

Exchange booths and shop ATMs

Street currency exchanges give poor rates with hidden fees, and ATMs inside cash-only shops add hefty charges. Bring a little cash and use a bank ATM.

Via [Sarah Funk](#), [Wolters World](#)

NEIGHBOURHOODS

Where to stay

Pick an area first, then a hotel. Every area card shows the latest recorded crime within about a mile, so you can compare busy against calm.



Photo: Original photography & stitching by Diliff, horizontal correction by ...

*Midtown East**/ Grand Central*

HIGH RECORDED CRIME

FIRST-TIMERS • FAMILIES

Walk to Grand Central, Rockefeller Center, Radio City and Times Square, but quieter at night than the Theater District. The easiest first-time base and the priciest. Recorded crime is about 2,100 a month within a mile, almost half theft - the circle overlaps busy Midtown.

2,060 crimes a month nearby • 47% theft • 19% violence or robbery

Via [Pictures of New York](#), [Traveling with Tim](#), [Sarah Funk](#), [Travel Tips Group](#), [Super.com](#), [TRIP XTREME](#)



Photo: Christian David • [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

Upper West Side

LOWER RECORDED CRIME

FAMILIES • CALM BASE

Quiet, residential and beside Central Park and the Natural History Museum, with good subway lines. Little nightlife. About 600 recorded crimes a month, a quarter of the Times Square figure.

583 crimes a month nearby • 48% theft • 17% violence or robbery

Via [Sarah Funk](#)

Upper East Side

LOWER RECORDED CRIME

FAMILIES • CALM BASE

Upscale and tranquil, with Museum Mile and Central Park on the doorstep. Hotels are pricier. One of the lowest crime counts in Manhattan in our sample.

615 crimes a month nearby • 55% theft • 14% violence or robbery

Via [TRIP XTREME](#)



Photo: King of Hearts • [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

Financial District

LOWER RECORDED CRIME

FAMILIES • VALUE

Cheaper than Midtown, well connected, and handy for the 9/11 Memorial and the ferries. Creators disagree on the evenings: one calls it very safe, another says it is quiet with few places to eat outside office hours. About 700 recorded crimes a month.

708 crimes a month nearby • 38% theft • 16% violence or robbery

Via [Traveling with Tim](#), [Travel Tips Group](#), [Sarah Funk](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)



Photo: King of Hearts • [CC BY-SA 3.0](#)

Long Island City

LOWEST RECORDED CRIME

VALUE • SOLO

The top budget tip from more than one creator: 10-15 minutes by subway to Midtown, cheaper hotels and a Manhattan skyline view. You will ride the train to every



Photo: diego_cue • [CC BY-SA 3.0](#)

DUMBO

LOWER RECORDED CRIME

FAMILIES • PHOTOGRAPHERS

The most picturesque base - cobbled streets, Brooklyn Bridge views and a ferry to Wall Street. Neighbouring Brooklyn Heights is a quiet brownstone area with a

sight, and there is a lot of construction. The lowest recorded crime of any area we checked.

400 crimes a month nearby • 33% theft • 21% violence or robbery

Via [Sarah Funk](#), [TRIP XTREME](#), [Wolters World](#)

waterfront promenade. About 30 minutes to Times Square.

885 crimes a month nearby • 39% theft • 20% violence or robbery

Via [Sarah Funk](#), [TRIP XTREME](#)

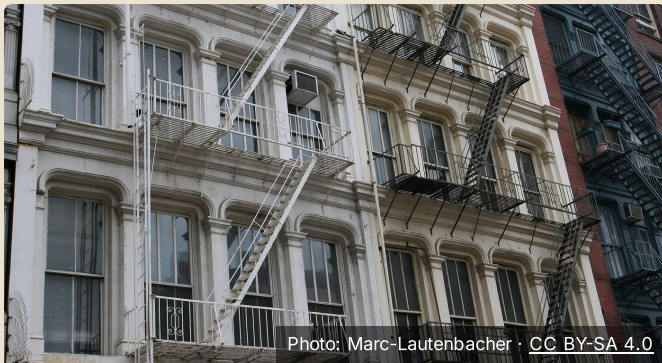


Photo: Marc-Lautenbacher · [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

Greenwich Village

MODERATE RECORDED CRIME

SOLO • FAMILIES

Brownstones, cafés, Washington Square Park and jazz bars. The West Village is one local creator's favourite area and, in their words, safe to walk at night – but hotels are few and book up fast.

1,467 crimes a month nearby • 52% theft • 16% violence or robbery

Via [Sarah Funk](#), [Pictures of New York](#), [TRIP XTREME](#)



Photo: 50greenestreet · [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

SoHo

MODERATE RECORDED CRIME

SOLO

Shopping, food and a huge number of subway lines, walkable to Chinatown and the Village. Crowded by day at weekends, quiet at night. Boutique hotels are pricey.

1,590 crimes a month nearby • 45% theft • 17% violence or robbery

Via [Sarah Funk](#), [Pictures of New York](#), [Super.com](#)



Photo: Jakub Hafun · [CC BY 4.0](#)

Williamsburg

LOWER RECORDED CRIME

SOLO • REPEAT VISITORS

Local feel, street art, live music and a strong food scene, with a ferry link to Manhattan. Best for a second trip. About 630 recorded crimes a month.

630 crimes a month nearby • 32% theft • 19% violence or robbery

Via [Sarah Funk](#), [Super.com](#), [TRIP XTREME](#)

Hotels we'd start with

Wiley Fox may earn a small commission if you book through these links. Your price stays the same.

MIDTOWN (FIFTH AVENUE) • FAMILIES

The Peninsula New York

Spacious suites with a mini kitchen and a heated rooftop pool open all year. Sarah Funk rates it for families; the lobby is also a free Christmas stop.

\$\$\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Sarah Funk](#)

MIDTOWN (NEAR PENN STATION) • FAMILIES

DoubleTree by Hilton New York Times Square South

Breakfast and a gym, walkable to Broadway and Penn Station - about \$176 a double in 2025.

\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Travel Tips Group](#)

LONG ISLAND CITY • FAMILIES & SOLO

Aloft Long Island City

Games area, bar and balconies, one stop from Manhattan. Typical rooms \$150-300, about \$250 at Christmas (2023).

\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Sarah Funk](#)

GREENWICH VILLAGE • FAMILIES & SOLO

Washington Square Hotel

An affordable three-star base beside Washington Square Park and the West Village.

\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via [Pictures of New York](#)

MIDTOWN • SOLO

Moxy NYC Times Square

MIDTOWN EAST • SOLO

Stylish and fairly priced, with a rooftop bar facing the Empire State. Suites from about \$300 in January to March 2026 with breakfast; about \$350 a night between Christmas and New Year in 2023.

\$\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via Sarah Funk

EVEN Hotel New York – Midtown East

Wellness-focused, with in-room exercise kit and very comfortable beds, near Grand Central.

\$\$ PRICE BAND

SEE PRICES

Via Maya Lee

Search all New York hotels

Compare live prices, then check the street on the Wiley Fox map before you book.

SEARCH BOOKING.COM

WF

Clip a Wiley Fox QR wristband on each child. If you get separated in a crowd, anyone who scans it can contact you straight away - no app needed on their side.

WHAT CREATORS RATE

Ten things worth your time

Ranked by how often creators recommend them. Book popular ones early.

01



Photo: Rhododendrites · [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

Central Park

CENTRAL PARK • GREAT FOR KIDS

Free, 840 acres and surprisingly peaceful. Allow at least two hours: Bethesda Terrace, the lake and boats, and the quieter Conservatory Garden in the north-east. Best by day.

Via [Nomac Guides](#), [Island Hopper TV](#)

Free

DETAILS

American Museum of Natural History

UPPER WEST SIDE • GREAT FOR KIDS

02

Dinosaurs, the blue whale and the Gilder Center's butterfly vivarium. Book ahead - the main queue is long - and allow two to three hours.

Via [Nomac Guides](#), [Eat See TV](#), [Jon Barr](#), [Island Hopper TV](#)

Paid

DETAILS

03



Photo: William Warby · [CC BY 2.0](#)

Statue of Liberty & Ellis Island

BATTERY PARK · GREAT FOR KIDS

Takes most of a day. Book ahead and take the first ferry; your time slot is for airport-style security, not the boat. Weekends are very busy - one creator suggests Monday or Tuesday mornings.

Via [Exotic Vacation](#), [Island Hopper TV](#), [Dicas Nova York](#)

About \$26-27 adult (2026)

DETAILS

04



Photo: MusikAnimal · [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

Brooklyn Bridge & DUMBO

DUMBO · GREAT FOR KIDS

Walk it early for soft light and joggers, or after dark when the cables are lit. Walk towards Manhattan so the skyline is in front of you. The Washington Street photo spot is busy even early.

Via [Nomac Guides](#), [Katelyn DeWitt](#), [Exotic Vacation](#)

Free

DETAILS

05



An observation deck

MIDTOWN & LOWER MANHATTAN • GREAT FOR KIDS

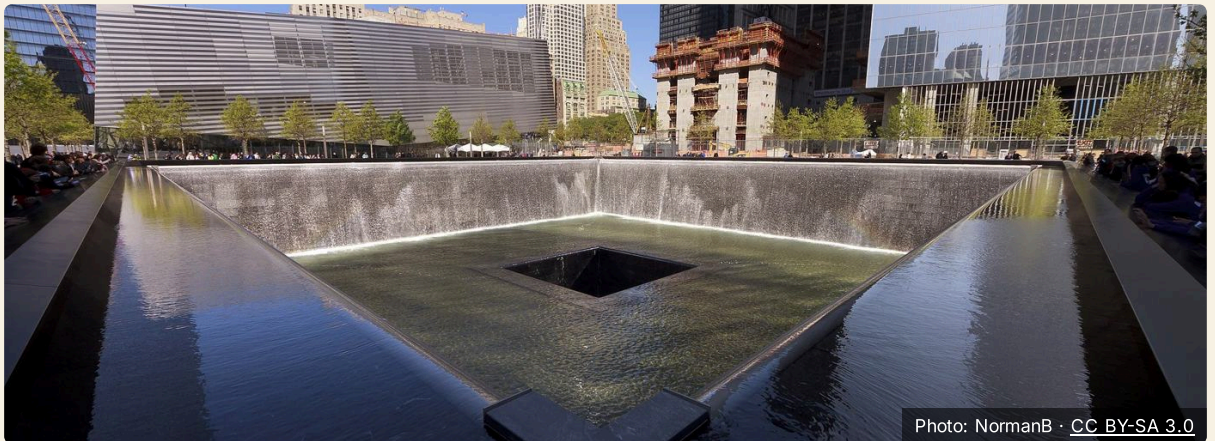
Creators can't agree on the best: Top of the Rock for the Empire State view, Summit One Vanderbilt for its mirrored rooms (a hit with small children), One World Observatory for all five boroughs. Book the first slot of the day for near-empty decks.

Via [Exotic Vacation](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Through My Lens](#), [Nomac Guides](#)

From about \$40 (2025)

DETAILS

06



9/11 Memorial & Museum

FINANCIAL DISTRICT

The memorial pools are free and deeply moving. The museum is detailed and some content is graphic - judge it for your children. Keep photos respectful.

Via [Nomac Guides](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Sarah Funk](#), [Manps On The Map](#)

Memorial free · museum about \$33

DETAILS

07

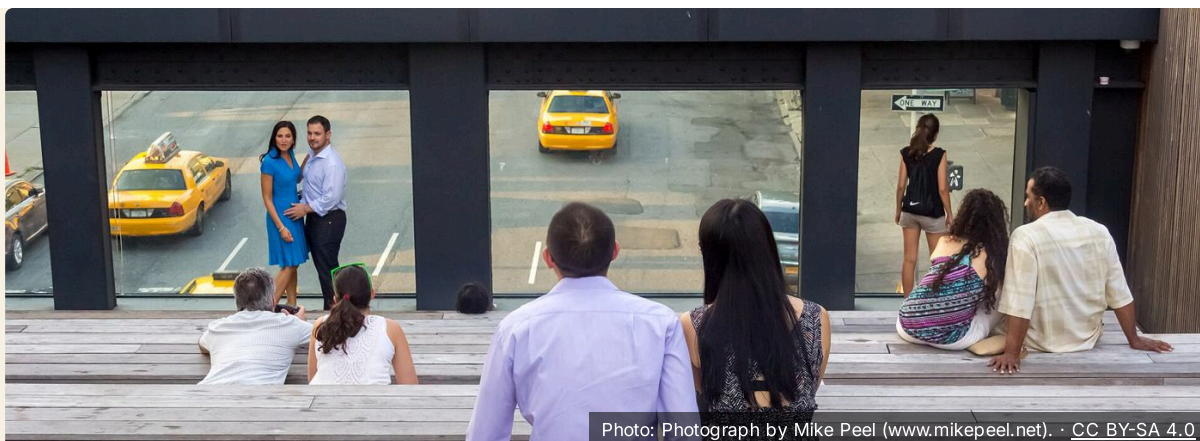


Photo: Photograph by Mike Peel (www.mikepeel.net). · CC BY-SA 4.0

High Line & Little Island

CHELSEA · GREAT FOR KIDS

A free elevated park on old railway tracks from the Meatpacking District to Hudson Yards, linked to Chelsea Market, with the Little Island floating park at Pier 55. Quieter in the morning.

Via [Island Hopper TV](#), [Nomac Guides](#)

Free

DETAILS

08

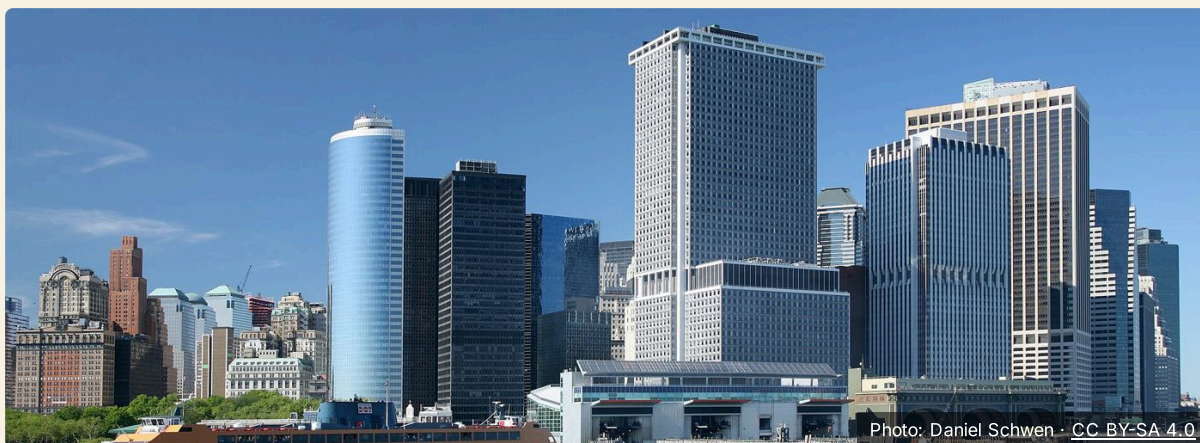


Photo: Daniel Schwen · CC BY-SA 4.0

Staten Island Ferry

BATTERY PARK · GREAT FOR KIDS

The free way to pass the Statue of Liberty - about an hour round trip. One creator who lived on Staten Island thinks it's a poor substitute for a Statue cruise: the view is brief and the terminals are grubby.

Via [Nomac Guides](#), [Traveling with Tim](#), [Expedia](#), [Sarah Funk](#)

Free

DETAILS

09



Photo: Wurts Bros. · [Public domain](#)

A Broadway show

THEATER DISTRICT · GREAT FOR KIDS

From about \$50 to \$150+ in 2024. For deals, try app-based lotteries the day before, TodayTix, or the TKTS booth in Times Square (40-50% off same day; queues start at 11am). Avoid street sellers.

Via [Exotic Vacation](#), [Manps On The Map](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Eat See TV](#)

From about \$50

DETAILS

10



Photo: Superbass · [CC BY-SA 4.0](#)

Roosevelt Island Tramway

ROOSEVELT ISLAND · GREAT FOR KIDS

One creator's best cheap view in the city: a cable car over the East River for the price of a subway ride, lovely at sunset. Go earlier in the day for smaller crowds.

Via [Leyla Tavas](#), [Nomac Guides](#), [Island Hopper TV](#)

Subway fare

DETAILS

If you only have one day

ONE

1

The classic loop

- 08:00 **Views first.** Take the first slot at Summit One Vanderbilt or Top of the Rock (book ahead) for near-empty decks.
- 10:00 **Library & Grand Central.** The free New York Public Library and Bryant Park next door (with the city's best public loos), then Grand Central.
- 12:00 **Lunch.** Los Tacos No. 1 near Grand Central, or chicken over rice from a halal cart.
- 13:30 **Central Park.** Walk up Fifth Avenue into the park: Bethesda Terrace and the lake. A Levain cookie on the Upper West Side.
- 16:30 **Downtown.** Subway to the 9/11 Memorial pools and the Oculus, then the NYC Ferry from Pier 11 to DUMBO.
- 18:30 **DUMBO & the bridge.** Pizza at Juliana's or Time Out Market, the free rooftop view, then walk the Brooklyn Bridge back towards the lit skyline.
-

Three days, grouped by area

DAY

1

Midtown classics

- AM First-slot observation deck, the Public Library and Grand Central.
- PM Rockefeller Center, Fifth Avenue and Central Park.
- EVE A Broadway show (TKTS or a lottery) and dinner at Carmine's - a quick look at Times Square, then home.
-

DAY

2

Harbour & Brooklyn

AM	First ferry to the Statue of Liberty and Ellis Island.
PM	9/11 Memorial and the Oculus, then the ferry from Pier 11 to DUMBO.
EVE	Juliana's or Time Out Market, and the Brooklyn Bridge walk after dark.

DAY

3

Museums & the West Side

AM	American Museum of Natural History (pre-booked), then Levain.
PM	The High Line to Chelsea Market (Los Tacos No. 1) and Little Island.
EVE	Dinner in the West Village; plan your route home.

WHAT CREATORS RATE

Where to eat

Every place is credited to the creator who recommended it.

Katz's Delicatessen

LOWER EAST SIDE • JEWISH DELI

\$\$

Pastrami on rye since 1888 - \$28.95 in 2026, and one sandwich feeds two. The queue moves fast; don't lose your ticket. Jon Barr finds it touristy and sends people to Sarge's Deli for value.

Family friendly

Via [National Geographic](#), [Through My Lens](#), [Only Scrans](#), [Jon Barr](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

VISIT

Russ & Daughters

LOWER EAST SIDE • BAGELS & SMOKED FISH

\$\$

A 100-year-old lox institution two minutes from Katz's. A lox bagel was \$17 in 2024.

Family friendly

Via [Through My Lens](#), [Jon Barr](#)

VISIT

Tompkins Square Bagels

EAST VILLAGE • BAGELS

\$

Fresh, fluffy bagels in some wild flavours, popular with New Yorkers. Go early for the freshest batch.

Family friendly

Via [Exotic Vacation](#), [adelala](#)

VISIT

Los Tacos No. 1

CHELSEA MARKET & NEAR GRAND CENTRAL • TACOS

\$

Several creators' pick for the best tacos in the city - about \$5 each in 2025. Vegetarians: flour tortillas use pork lard, so ask for corn.

Family friendly

Via [Through My Lens](#), [Manps On The Map](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [adelala](#)

VISIT

Joe's Pizza

GREENWICH VILLAGE & TIMES SQUARE • PIZZA BY THE SLICE

\$

The classic New York slice since 1975 - about \$4 for cheese in 2025. Creators disagree: Jon Barr calls it overrated and prefers Bleecker Street Pizza nearby; another found Slice House in the West Village much quieter.

Family friendly

Via [Oriana Findlay](#), [Jon Barr](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Harrison Webb](#)

VISIT

Prince Street Pizza

NOLITA • PIZZA BY THE SLICE

\$

Known for its thick pepperoni square - one creator's favourite slice in the city.

Family friendly

Via [adelala](#)

VISIT

Juliana's

DUMBO • COAL-OVEN PIZZA

\$\$

Thin, crisp pies by the Brooklyn Bridge - from \$26 a pie in 2024. Arrive early; there's always a queue.

Family friendly

Via [Nomac Guides](#), [Jon Barr](#)

VISIT

Jin Mei Dumplings

CHINATOWN • DUMPLINGS

\$

15 pork and chive dumplings for about \$5 in 2024, on Henry Street. Many Chinatown places are cash only.

Family friendly

Via [TOPJAW](#), [Pictures of New York](#)

VISIT

Carmine's

THEATER DISTRICT • FAMILY-STYLE ITALIAN

\$\$

Big sharing platters near Times Square - about \$30-40 a head in 2024. Book ahead, especially before a show.

Family friendly

Via [Exotic Vacation](#)

VISIT

Tick Tock Diner

MIDTOWN (OPPOSITE PENN STATION) • 24-HOUR DINER

\$

Huge pancake and French toast plates, any hour - breakfasts \$9.95 to \$20 in 2025.

Family friendly

Via [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

VISIT

Levain Bakery

UPPER WEST SIDE • BAKERY

\$

Thick, gooey cookies that live up to the hype. The original small shop on 74th Street, near Central Park, is the one to visit.

Family friendly

Via [Manps On The Map](#)

VISIT

Magnolia Bakery

WEST VILLAGE, GRAND CENTRAL & HUDSON YARDS • BAKERY

\$

Famous banana pudding - \$4.95 for a small in 2024. Order ahead online to skip the queue.

Family friendly

Via [Through My Lens](#), [Manps On The Map](#), [Jon Barr](#), [adelala](#)

VISIT

Time Out Market

DUMBO • FOOD HALL

\$\$

Ramen, fried chicken and more under one roof, and a free rooftop with views of both bridges. In winter, Sugar Hill Creamery does a toasted-marshmallow hot chocolate.

Family friendly

Via [Manps On The Map](#), [Nomac Guides](#)

For a grown-ups' drink, Through My Lens rates Sip & Guzzle in the West Village among the world's top cocktail bars (about \$20-22 a drink in 2025), and Wolters World points to Ninth Avenue in Hell's Kitchen for better prices than Times Square. Tip about \$1 a drink at bars. Opening times and menus change, so check before you travel. Wiley Fox is not paid for restaurant listings.

BEFORE YOU GO

Getting around New York

From the airports

From JFK, the AirTrain plus the subway gets you to Manhattan for under \$15 in about an hour; the AirTrain plus the Long Island Rail Road from Jamaica is quicker (as little as 20 minutes) and has luggage racks. From LaGuardia a free shuttle bus runs to the subway. From Newark take NJ Transit to the last stop, New York Penn Station - not Newark Penn. A taxi or Uber costs around \$100, and surge pricing can push Uber higher; use the official taxi line.

Via [Sarah Funk](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Nomac Guides](#), [Exotic Vacation](#), [Traveling with Tim](#)

Tap to pay

No MetroCard needed: tap a contactless card or phone at the subway gate or on a local bus. A ride is \$3, and after 12 paid rides in seven days the rest are free, so a week tops out at \$35 (MTA, Sept 2026). Each person needs their own card or device for the cap. There's no need to tap out.

Via [Jon Barr](#), [Nomac Guides](#), [Sarah Funk](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Pictures of New York](#)

Subway know-how

Stand well back from the platform edge. If you want crew nearby, wait by the black-and-white striped board mid-platform - it lines up with the conductor's car. An empty car is empty for a reason (often no heating or a bad smell). Platforms and trains have help points, and busy stations usually have police. Wet or snowy steps get slippery.

Via [Mohuya Khan](#), [thefunsizedfoodie](#), [Sarah Funk](#), [The Megan Daily](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

Late at night

Creators disagree. Several ride at any hour and say normal awareness is enough; two women creators avoid the subway after about 11pm to midnight, when trains are fewer and platforms emptier, and take a car or a bus with the driver present instead. If you're alone, plan the last leg home before you go out.

Via [Wolters World](#), [Nomac Guides](#), [Sarah Funk](#)

Ferries

The Staten Island Ferry is free, runs 24 hours about every 30 minutes and passes the Statue of Liberty - sit on the right on the way out. The NYC Ferry from Pier 11 (Wall Street) to DUMBO takes under five minutes;

Cheap scenic rides

The Roosevelt Island Tramway is a three-minute cable car over the East River for the price of a subway ride. Downtown, the free Downtown Connection bus loops past Battery Park, the Seaport and the 9/11

creators quoted \$4 in 2025 and \$4.50 in 2026. The Governors Island ferry was \$5 return in 2026.

Via [Traveling with Tim](#), [Nomac Guides](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Jon Barr](#)

Memorial (10am to 7.30pm in 2026). Hop-on buses crawl at rush hour - ride 9-11am or 2-3pm.

Via [Island Hopper TV](#), [Nomac Guides](#), [Leyla Tavas](#)

Taxis and ride-hailing

A yellow taxi is free only when its roof light is lit. Avoid taxis and ride-hailing at rush hour - traffic is gridlocked and surge pricing can make an Uber twice the price of a cab.

Via [Jon Barr Shorts](#), [Wolters World](#)

Don't drive

Every creator who mentions it says no: tolls on most bridges and tunnels, a 25 mph limit, no right turn on red, and hotel parking charged daily. Walk, and wear broken-in shoes - you'll do a lot of it.

Via [Mileage Mike](#), [Sarah Funk](#), [Travel Tips Group](#), [Jon Barr Shorts](#)

What it costs

Subway or local bus ride (tap to pay)	\$3 Sept 2026
Weekly fare cap (12 rides, then free)	\$35 Sept 2026
ESTA (UK visitors)	\$40 Since 30 Sept 2025
JFK to Manhattan by AirTrain + subway	under \$15 May 2026
Three-star Midtown hotel	about \$250-350 a night Dec 2024 - far more at Christmas
Top of the Rock	from about \$40 Oct 2025
Cheese slice of pizza	about \$4 Aug 2026
Pastrami sandwich at Katz's	\$28.95 Apr 2026

Creator prices carry the video date. Anything older than 18 months is marked to check.

Quick tips

Book the first slot

Observation decks, the Statue of Liberty ferry and even Times Square are calm first thing. Creators who booked the earliest slot had rooms almost to themselves.

Step aside to stop

New Yorkers walk fast. Pull to the side of the pavement for photos or maps, and know your order before you reach the counter.

Carry a little cash

Some carts and bodegas take cards only above a minimum, many Chinatown restaurants are cash only, and shop ATMs can turn a \$3 snack into \$8.

Don't eat in Times Square

Prices are higher and it's mostly chains. Walk a few blocks to Ninth Avenue in Hell's Kitchen for local places.

Check free museum times

Several museums have free or pay-what-you-wish slots, such as MoMA on Friday evenings (reserve ahead). Check each museum's site for current times.

Book a hotel, not a flat

Short-term rentals have been effectively banned since a 2023 law. Stick to hotels, and book early for December.

Spotted a scam hotspot or a street that felt wrong? Drop a community report on the map - it helps rate the area for the next family.

THE SMALL THINGS VISITORS WORRY ABOUT

Local tips for New York

Every tip here was checked against an official or trusted source on the date shown. Rules and prices change, so tap the link to double-check before you travel.

Paying for transport

Do I need to buy a MetroCard?

No need to queue for a ticket: tap your contactless bank card, phone or watch at the OMNY reader on the subway or local bus. The fare is \$3 a ride (checked Sept 2026). [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Is there a weekly fare cap?

With OMNY, once you've paid for 12 rides in seven days the rest are free, so weekly spend on subways and local buses tops out at \$35 (checked Sept 2026). Use the same card or phone every time. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Do my kids pay on the subway?

Up to three children under 44 inches (about 112 cm) tall ride subways and local buses free with a paying adult, so don't tap for very small ones. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Can we all use one card?

Use the same card or phone for both legs of a journey to get your free transfer, and note that fare-capping is tracked per card, so don't swap between cards or devices.

[Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

What about the commuter trains like LIRR and Metro-North?

For the LIRR or Metro-North, buy your ticket in the TrainTime app or at a machine beforehand: buying from the conductor on board adds a surcharge. Children under 5 travel free. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Water & snacks

Do I need to buy bottled water?

Skip the bottled water: New York's tap water is safe to drink and comes from upstate reservoirs, so just refill a reusable bottle at your hotel or a park fountain.

Checked 2026-09 ↗

Will grocery snacks have tax added?

Picking up snacks and drinks from a grocery store or deli? Most unprepared food isn't charged sales tax, so the shelf price is usually what you pay, unlike restaurant meals. Checked 2026-09 ↗

Toilets

When are park loos open?

Most NYC Parks public toilets are open roughly 8am to 4pm daily, and later in some seasons, so don't leave it until dusk. Look for a café or hotel lobby after that.

Checked 2026-09 ↗

Where can I find a decent loo in Midtown?

Bryant Park's toilets are a Midtown favourite, kept smart with attendants, and Grand Central Terminal, libraries and big department stores are handy backups when you need one. Checked 2026-09 ↗

CHRISTMAS ***Are there toilets at the Bryant Park Winter Village?***

Yes, public toilets are available throughout Bryant Park during Winter Village hours, so you can plan a skate or shopping stop without hunting for one. Checked 2026-09 ↗

CHRISTMAS ***Are there toilets at the Times Square New Year's Eve crowd?***

There are no portable toilets in the Times Square New Year's Eve viewing area, and if you leave you can't get back to your spot, so go before you enter the pens and limit what you drink. Checked 2026-09 ↗

Parks & play

Can we use any NYC playground?

Playgrounds are free, but check the rules sign at the entrance: bikes, scooters, skateboards and pets are not allowed, and at many playgrounds adults can only go in with a child. Checked 2026-09 ↗

CHRISTMAS ***Is the Bryant Park skating rink free?***

The Rink at Bryant Park's Winter Village has free admission if you bring your own skates, but you still need to reserve a free ticket in advance. Hiring skates costs extra and

prices are on the official site.

Checked 2026-09 ↗

CHRISTMAS *Can we browse Winter Village without paying?*

Entry to Bryant Park's Winter Village holiday shops is free. The 2026 to 27 season is listed as starting 28 October, so it's easy to fit in on the way to other Midtown sights.

Checked 2026-09 ↗

Money & tipping

How much should I tip in restaurants?

Tipping is expected: around 20% is standard in sit-down restaurants, and under 18% usually signals you weren't happy. Tips are not included in menu prices.

Checked 2026-09 ↗

Why is my bill higher than the menu prices?

Prices on tags and menus don't include sales tax, which is added at the till. New York City's combined rate is 8.875%.

Checked 2026-09 ↗

Is there tax on clothes?

Clothing and footwear costing under \$110 per item aren't charged sales tax in NYC, so that pair of trainers might be cheaper than the maths suggests. Items at \$110 or more pay the full rate. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Could a service charge already be on the bill?

Always check the bill: large groups sometimes have a gratuity or service charge added automatically, so you may not need to tip on top. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Phones & data

Will I get stung by roaming charges?

Check your UK provider's roaming charges for the USA before you fly, set a spend limit,

Is there a cheaper way to get data?

A local SIM or an eSIM for your destination can be cheaper than roaming, and it's worth

and turn off data roaming if you don't have a bundle. Use Wi-Fi where you can.

Checked 2026-09 ↗

downloading maps and shows on Wi-Fi before you go. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Will my UK chargers work?

US sockets run at 120V and take Type A and B plugs, so pack a travel adaptor. Most phone and laptop chargers cope with 120V, but check the label on hairdryers and straighteners first. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Safety habits

Who do I call in an emergency?

For emergencies (police, fire, medical), dial 911. For non-emergency city help, call or text 311, which has interpreters in over 175 languages, 24/7. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

How do I keep my things safe on the subway?

On the subway, keep bags in front of you and stay aware of your phone and belongings, especially on crowded trains and platforms. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Where should I stand on the platform?

Stand well back from the platform edge, behind the yellow line, and look for the black and white striped board overhead near the middle of the platform to board near the conductor. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

What should I do when crossing the road?

Even with a walk signal, look around for turning vehicles, especially left-turners: NYC DOT says three in four pedestrian crashes happen at intersections.

[Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

CHRISTMAS ***What should I bring to Times Square on New Year's Eve?***

Leave backpacks, large bags, umbrellas and alcohol behind, as all bags are searched. Viewing areas open at 3pm

(2025 times, so check again this year) and fill first come, first served. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Local ways

Do I need anything before flying from the UK?

British visitors need an approved ESTA before flying. Apply only on the official esta.cbp.dhs.gov site (the fee was \$40 from 30 Sept 2025), and apply well ahead of your trip. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

How do I stay safe around bikes and e-bikes?

Look both ways in bike lanes as well as on the road: cyclists follow the same traffic rules as drivers, e-bikes are capped at 15mph and should stay off pavements and yield to pedestrians. [Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

CHRISTMAS *When is the Rockefeller tree lit this year?*

The 2026 Rockefeller Center tree lighting date hasn't been published yet, so check rockefellercenter.com nearer the time and don't plan flights around a guess.

[Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

CHRISTMAS *How do I see the Christmas windows without the crush?*

The famous Fifth Avenue and Herald Square window displays are busiest earlier in the evening, so go once most tourists have gone to bed for a closer look. Check retailers' sites for opening dates.

[Checked 2026-09 ↗](#)

Travel with Wiley Fox

Live crime maps, Safest Route home, one-tap SOS, and QR wristbands so lost children and lost bags find their way back.

Our sources

This guide summarises these creators' videos in our own words. Watch the originals - they are worth it. Crime data: NYPD Complaint Data (NYC Open Data) (Apr 2026 to Jun 2026). Crime complaints recorded by the NYPD from April to June 2026 (the latest published), counted within about one mile of each area centre. These are reports, not convictions. They include indoor and domestic incidents and minor harassment, exclude traffic and administrative offences, and are not adjusted for the millions of visitors who pass through busy areas.

1. [trying the best NYC food spots!!!! \(must watch guide before you visit\)](#)
adelala · 2025-10
2. [10 BEST THINGS TO DO IN NEW YORK CITY AT CHRISTMAS](#)
Creative Travel Guide · 2024-11
3. [Christmas in NYC is A MESS 🤔](#)
Danny Rayes · 2023-12
4. [NOVA YORK EM DEZEMBRO: Clima, como se vestir e dicas imperdíveis 🌲🎅](#)
Dicas Nova York · 2025-10
5. [The PERFECT Trip to New York City! Best Things to Do & Eat \(Travel Guide\)](#)
Eat See TV · 2024-09
6. [How to Spend 4 Days in NEW YORK | Travel Itinerary](#)
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9. [CHRISTMAS IN NEW YORK CITY | Tips & BEST Things to Do, Lights, Attractions \(FULL GUIDE\)](#)
Happy to Wander · 2023-12
10. [I Asked Strangers Where to Eat in New York](#)
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11. [Best Things To Do in New York City 4K](#)
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12. [Best Things To Do in New York City 2026 4K](#)
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13. [7 Secrets Every NYC Tourist Needs To Know!](#)
Jon Barr · 2022-10
14. [NYC's BIGGEST Scams, Rip-Offs, and Tourist Traps in 2024 \(Times Square and More!\)](#)
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15. [I Ranked NYC's Most Famous Restaurants from WORST to BEST!](#)
Jon Barr · 2024-07
16. [How To See NYC in 3 Days \(Without The Stress!\)](#)
Jon Barr · 2025-01
17. [25 ESSENTIAL New York City Tips in 10 Minutes!](#)
Jon Barr Shorts · 2025-09
18. [NYC Travel Mistakes: What NOT to Do in New York City](#)
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19. [The Perfect Christmas in NYC - Everything You Need to Know!](#)
Jon Barr Shorts · 2025-10
20. [How To See NYC in 4 Days \(Without The Stress!\)](#)
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21. [the PERFECT nyc holiday itinerary 🌲 local recs + viral tourist stuff WORTH doing *pinterest inspired*](#)
Katelyn DeWitt · 2025-12
22. [30 things to do in New York 🗽🚗 *dream NYC trip*](#)
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23. [The Festive Guide to Christmas in New York City 2026!](#)
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24. [The ULTIMATE New York City Food Tour 2026!](#)
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25. [Where to Stay in NYC 🍎🏠](#)
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26. [New York in December: Should you visit NOW?](#)
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27. [10 Rules I Learned Driving in NEW YORK CITY For the FIRST Time](#)
Mileage Mike · 2023-03
28. [HOW TO STAY SAFE IN NYC // tips for tourists, riding the subway, + common scams to avoid!](#)
Mohuya Khan · 2023-04
29. [New York City's Most Iconic Foods in 24 Hours | Epic Food Journeys with Mark Wiens | Nat Geo](#)
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30. [The Ultimate 3 Day New York City Itinerary](#)
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31. [The Ultimate Transportation Guide to New York City 🇺🇸](#)
Nomac Guides · 2026-08
32. [25 FREE Things to do in New York City in 2026 🇺🇸](#)
Nomac Guides · 2026-08
33. [48 Hours Eating New York's Most FAMOUS Food!](#)
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34. [NEW YORK FOOD GUIDE 🇺🇸 | Ultimate Manhattan Food Tour](#)
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35. [Where to Stay in New York: Best Areas and Worst Areas \(Guide from a Local\) | 4K](#)
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36. [Preparing to visit NYC: Tips & What to Expect \(FIRST TIMERS MUST WATCH\)](#)
Sarah Funk · 2023-05
37. [Unspoken RULES of NYC - What I wish I Knew Before Coming](#)
Sarah Funk · 2023-09
38. [Where to stay in NYC without going broke | Hotels, Apartments, and More](#)
Sarah Funk · 2023-11
39. [Everything to AVOID in NYC That No One Talks About](#)
Sarah Funk · 2025-08
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